



2025 TOWN SURVEY

REPORT ON SURVEY RESPONSES

TOPICS

Trees • Civic Engagement • Fossil Fuels

Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion • Education

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INTRODUCTION

Since 1992, Envision Arlington has invited the community to share ideas through an annual survey using the census mailing to reach all households. Envision works with town departments and committees to discuss community and governmental operations for future improvements.

The 2025 survey focused on the Net Zero Action Plan, Tree Canopy Plan, Arlington Community Media, and Civic Engagement. Conducted online from January 1 to March 4, 2024, with paper copies available at the Robbins Library, the survey received 3,268 responses, over 200 more than in 2024. The survey reflects the views of participants, which may not fully represent the town's population. Respondent diversity is reported as percentages, potentially exceeding 100% when individuals identify with multiple categories.

Although respondent demographics may not perfectly reflect Arlington's demographics, the data collected plays a vital role in shaping town planning, policy updates, and community programs. Survey results, dating back to 2010, are available on the Envision Arlington webpage. Each year, findings are shared during Town Day, ensuring transparency and accessibility.



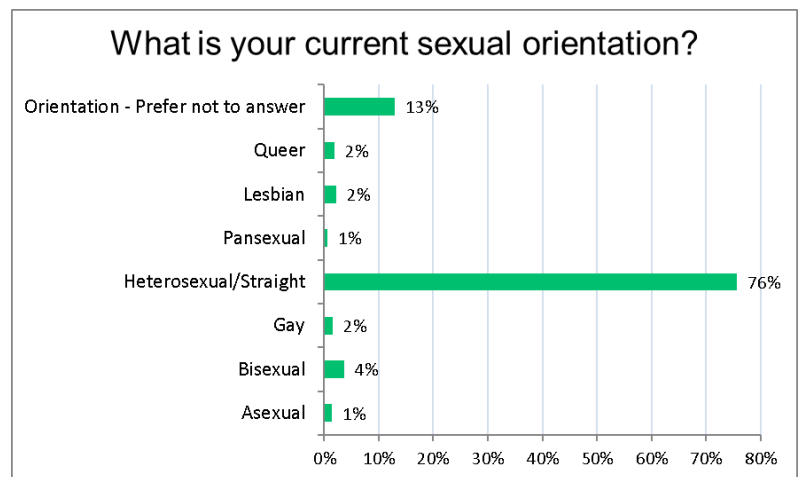
Figure 1. Languages spoken at home by survey respondents.

DEMOGRAPHICS

In the 2025 Town of Arlington Survey, the highest Precinct representation of respondents was from Precinct 2 and Precinct 12 with 7% of the 3,268 total responses each. These figures were more than double the voice of Precinct 18 at 3%, mirroring a similar distribution observed last year.

The racial and ethnic breakdown of respondents was as follows: 87% identified as White, 12% as Asian, 3% as Black, and 3% as other, while 7% chose not to disclose their race or ethnicity. In terms of Hispanic origin, 82% identified as non-Hispanic, 6% as Hispanic, and 9% did not provide this information. These figures are consistent with data from the 2020 United States Census. Additionally, 84% of respondents reported speaking only English at home, while 16% indicated they speak a range of other languages, including Spanish, French, Russian, Mandarin, and Portuguese, among others.

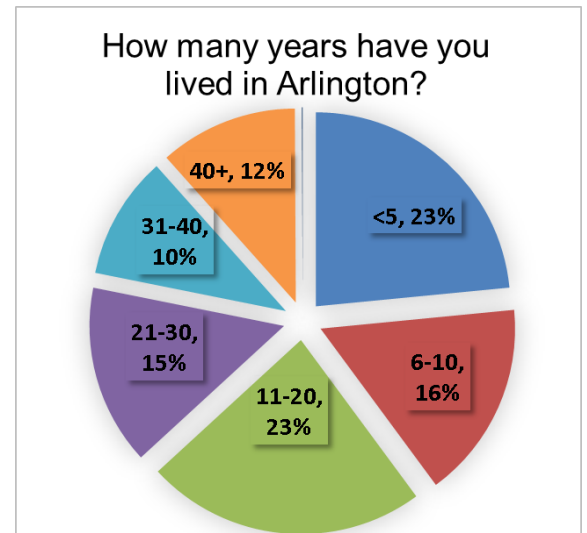
Respondents' gender identification was reported as 57% female, 38% male, 1% non-binary, and less than 1% transgender and another gender, with 3% opting not to disclose their gender. In terms of sexual orientation, of those answering the question, just under 12% identified as non-heterosexual, and 76% identified as heterosexual, with 32% preferring not to answer or skipping the question.



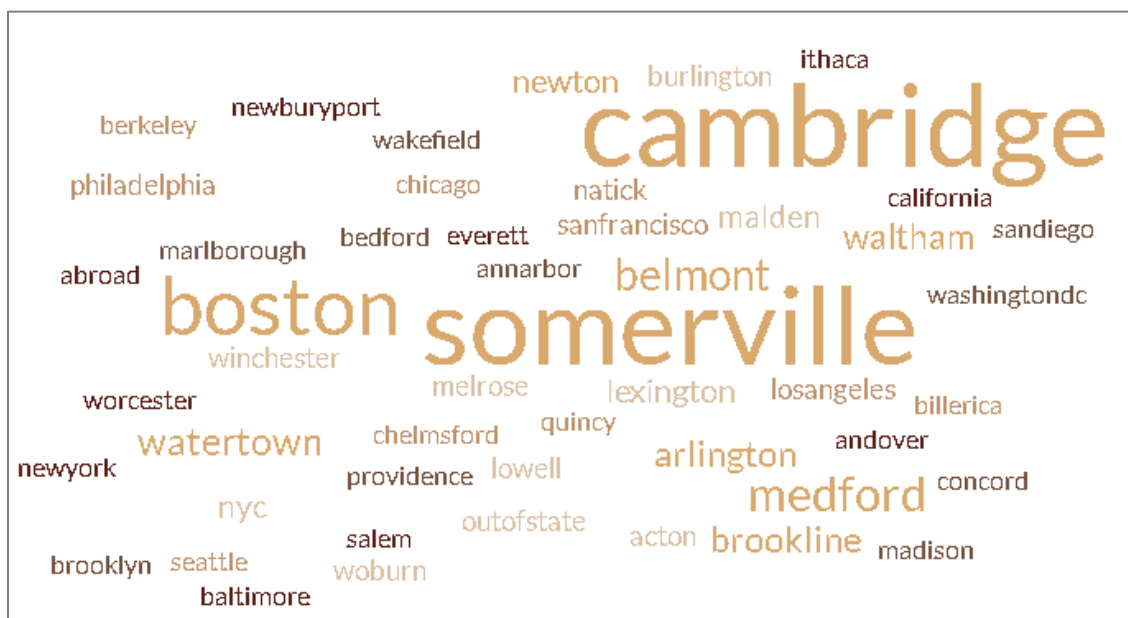
The majority of respondents were aged between 35 and 64 years, with 22% aged 35-44, 23% aged 45-54, 17% aged 55-64, and 16% aged 65-74. Fewer respondents fell into the age brackets of 25-34 (10%) and 15-24 (minimal), with 2% not disclosing their age.

Household composition was reported as follows: 67% of respondents live in households with two adults, 19% with one adult, 9% with three adults, 4% with four adults, and 1% with five or more adults. Furthermore, 61% of respondents reported having no children under 18 in their household. Among the remaining respondents, 17% have one child, 18% have two children, 3% have three children, and less than 1% have four or more children. Additionally, 10% of respondents reported having a physical, sensory, cognitive, emotional, or mental illness or disability that may limit or shape their participation in work and society, while 84% reported no disabilities.

The survey results indicated that 77% of participants own their homes, while 22% rent. This differs from Point2Homes statistics that find the split at 60% own and 40% rent. Another 2% cited alternative housing situations, such as cohabitation with family, residing in senior living facilities, or living in assisted living. The age of participants who have lived in Arlington is fairly evenly distributed over categories: 15% for 0 to 10 years, 15% for 11 to 20 years, 15% for 21 to 30 years, 15% for 31 to 40 years, 10% for 41 to 50 years, and 30% for 51 to 60 years. To gain insight into migration patterns in and out of Arlington, we



To gain insight into migration patterns in and out of Arlington, we posed two key questions:



**If you moved to
Arlington, what
town did you live
in previously?**

The data was normalized to group similar entries together—for example, all Boston neighborhoods were categorized

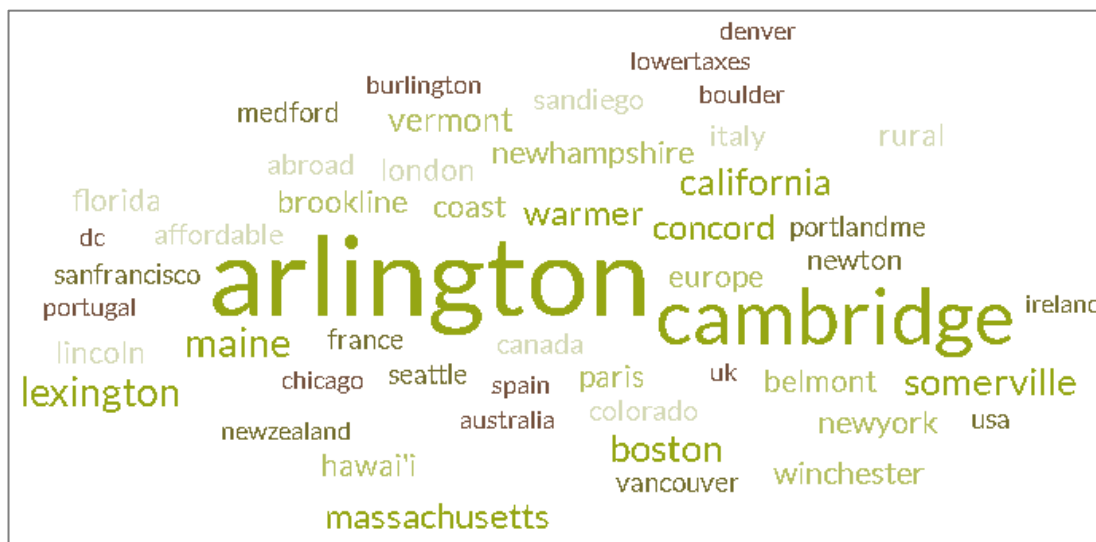
under "Boston," and "Overseas" was combined into "Abroad." Categories like "New England," combined with "Out of State." "Not Applicable," or "Not Sure" were omitted. The analysis revealed the top five towns respondents moved from: Cambridge (20%), Somerville (18%), Boston (12%), Medford (5%), Belmont (4%), and Watertown (3%). Arlington accounted for 2%, representing individuals who

either relocated within the town or indicated they were born there. This data highlights a general trend of migration from higher-density areas in the east to lower-density regions in the west.

**Where would you live
if you could live
anywhere else?**

The most popular choice for relocating was Arlington, with approximately 17% of respondents expressing their love for the area.

(This figure accounts for



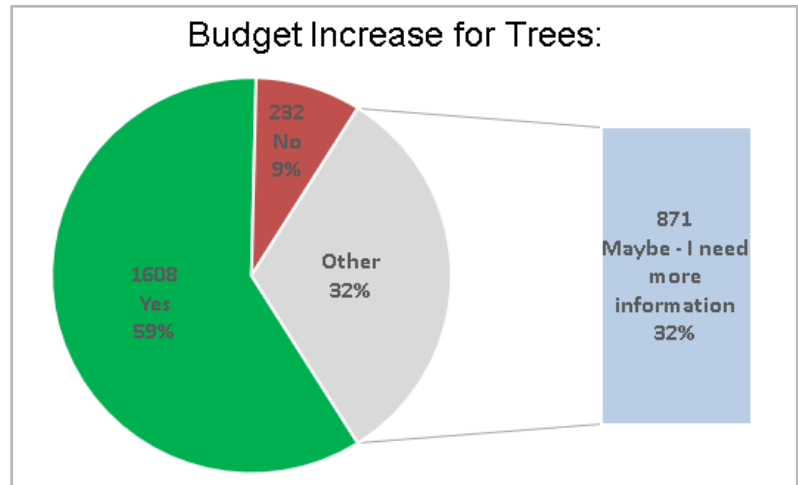
normalizing responses where "Here" or specific Arlington neighborhoods were grouped under Arlington.) While Arlington led the way, other preferences emerged, including warmer climates (2%), coastal areas (2%), or locations near the ocean. Additional mentions included affordability and lower taxes as key factors for relocation.

Beyond Arlington, respondents also showed interest in Cambridge (10%), Lexington (3%), Maine (3%), Somerville (3%), and Boston (3%). Several other locations garnered at least 2% of the vote, such as California, Concord, Winchester, Vermont, New York, New Hampshire, and other parts of Massachusetts. If responses were grouped by state rather than specific towns, states like California would likely show even higher percentages.

Interestingly, opinions were split between those favoring a return to higher-density urban areas like Cambridge, Somerville, and Boston, and those drawn to more rural settings such as Maine, Lexington, or other greener pastures.

TREE COMMITTEE

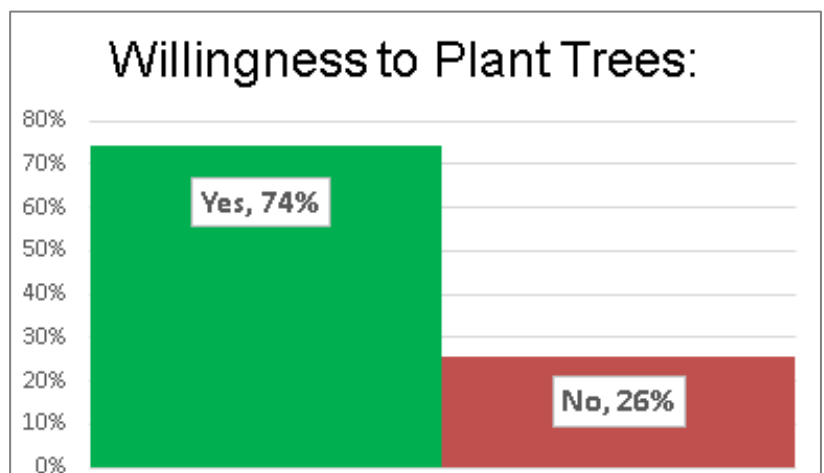
Support for Budget Increase by Precinct				
Precinct no.	Maybe: need more information	No	Yes	Grand Total
3	22%	2%	76%	100%
	24	2	84	110
6	23%	5%	71%	100%
	30	7	91	128
8	26%	6%	69%	100%
	36	8	96	140
17	28%	5%	67%	100%
	27	5	65	97
7	29%	5%	66%	100%
	36	6	81	123
12	27%	7%	66%	100%
	47	12	113	172
4	35%	2%	63%	100%
	42	2	76	120
9	32%	7%	61%	100%
	29	6	55	90
5	28%	12%	60%	100%
	32	14	70	116
1	35%	7%	59%	100%
	32	6	54	92
14	38%	5%	57%	100%
	42	6	64	112
19	32%	11%	57%	100%
	45	15	79	139
13	31%	13%	56%	100%
	37	16	68	121
20	35%	9%	56%	100%
	39	10	62	111
21	35%	9%	56%	100%
	48	13	77	138
10	35%	9%	55%	100%
	49	13	77	139
16	36%	9%	55%	100%
	45	11	69	125
15	34%	12%	55%	100%
	32	11	52	95
11	31%	17%	52%	100%
	33	18	56	107
2	42%	7%	51%	100%
	73	12	88	173
18	39%	14%	47%	100%
	34	12	41	87
Grand Total	32%	8%	60%	100%
	812	205	1,518	2,535



The Arlington Tree Committee envisions the town as a thriving, diverse, and resilient urban forest that benefits every resident's well-being, supports biodiversity, and strengthens climate resilience. Its mission is to increase the town's tree canopy coverage to 40% by 2040 with the help of residents, businesses, and government, in order to leave a lasting tree legacy for future generations.

Would you be in favor of increasing the Town's budget to plant, nurture, and maintain more trees? Fifty-nine percent (59%) of respondents favor increasing the Town's budget to plant, nurture, and maintain more trees. Precincts 3, 6, and 8 had the highest support, around 70%. Overall, 32% needed more information, with Precincts 2 and 18 leading this group at around 40% each.

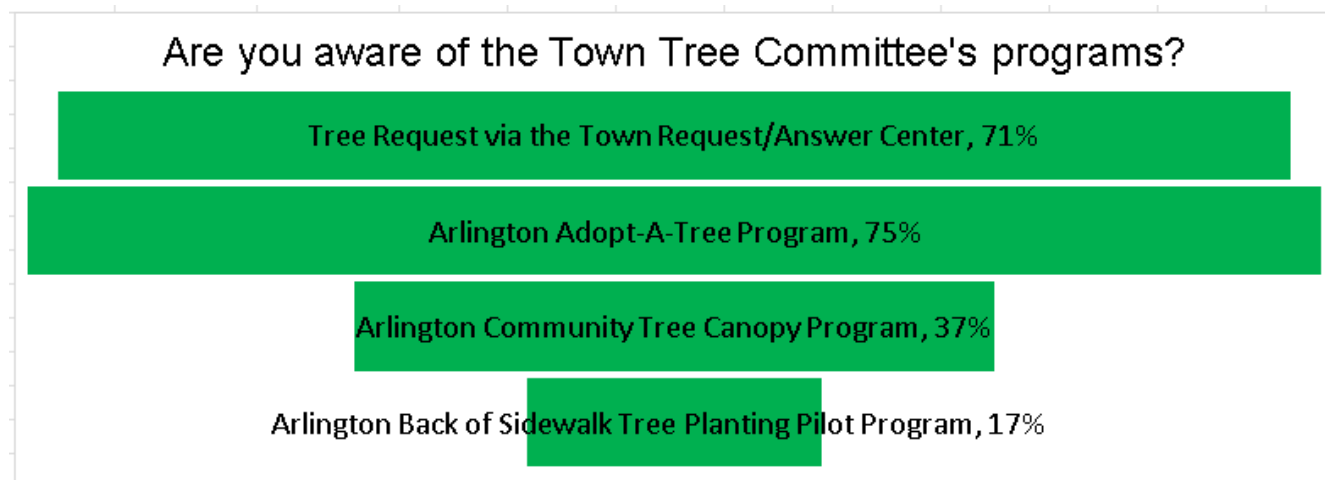
Would your household be willing to plant a tree on your property if the Town covers some or all of the costs and delivers the tree? Willingness to participate (74%) was almost three times greater than unwillingness (26%).



Are you aware of the Town's multi-year plan to expand Arlington's tree canopy to combat greenhouse gas emissions, increasing temperatures, and flooding? Awareness about the 2040 Tree Canopy Program was below average, as 58% were not aware of the town's multi-year plan to expand the Town's tree canopy to combat greenhouse gas emissions, increasing temperatures, and flooding. Age was associated with awareness in the Tree Canopy Program, as more awareness is observed to increase with age. Only 30% of respondents under 44 years were aware of this plan.

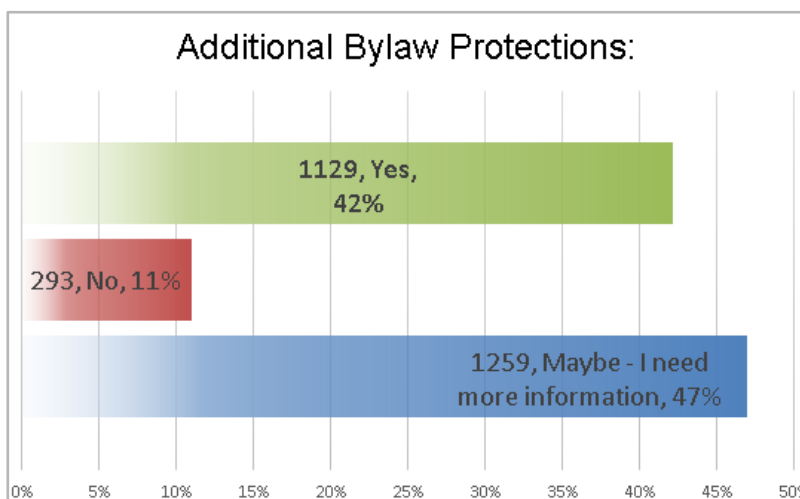
Are you aware of the Town Tree Committee's programs?

Newer residents were notably less informed compared to longer-term residents. Among those who were aware, familiarity with the Adopt-a-Tree Program and the Town's Request-a-Tree initiative was impressively high, at 75% and 71% respectively. However, awareness of the Tree Canopy Program within this group was significantly lower at 37%, and knowledge of the Back-of-Sidewalk Pilot Program was even more limited, at just 17%.



Currently, the Town Bylaw offers some protection to trees within private property setbacks. Would you be in favor of adding additional language to the Bylaw to expand on those protections, allowing for additional canopy preservation?

The proposal to add a by-law protecting trees on private property received a mixed but generally positive response. While 42% expressed clear support, 47% were open to learning more, and only 11% opposed the idea outright.



FOSSIL FUELS

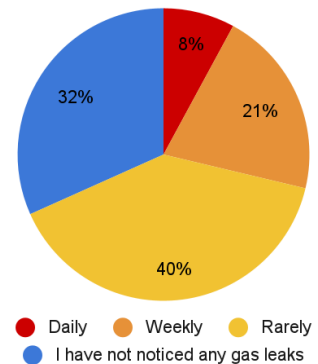
The Town's Net Zero Action Plan prioritizes addressing natural gas leaks and promoting electric alternatives to fossil fuel appliances in order to achieve net zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2050. To stabilize our climate, it will be necessary to transition off of fossil fuels onto clean sources of electricity.

Natural Gas Leaks

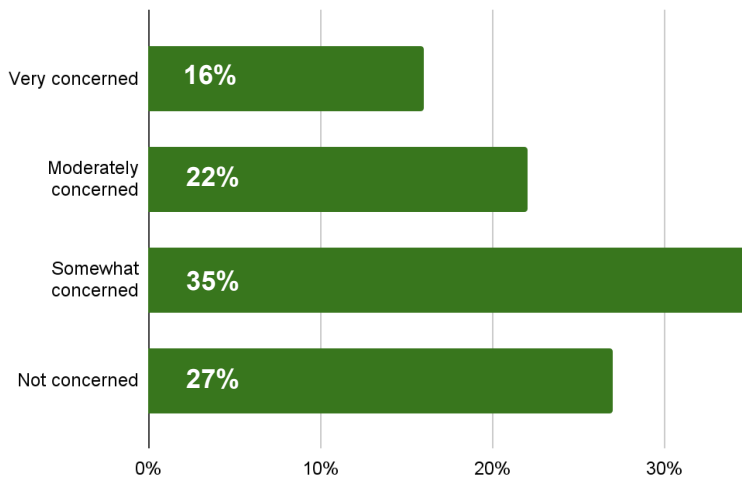
Most respondents are both aware of and concerned about gas leaks in Arlington. More than two-thirds of respondents (68%) have smelled natural gas leaks in Arlington, and more than a quarter (29%) do so daily or weekly. Almost three quarters of respondents (73%) indicated that they are concerned about natural gas leaks, with more than a third (38%) moderately or very concerned.

A quarter of respondents (24%) expressed concern about the health and environmental impacts of natural gas appliances, and a large majority of respondents (87%) are aware of them.

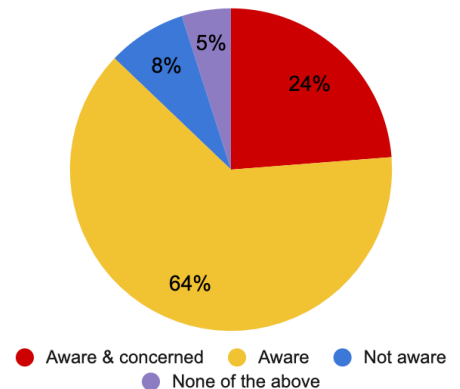
How often do you smell natural gas leaks in Arlington?



How concerned are you about natural gas leaks in Arlington?



Are you aware that natural gas appliances (boilers, furnaces, stoves, etc.) produce emissions that harm human and environmental health?

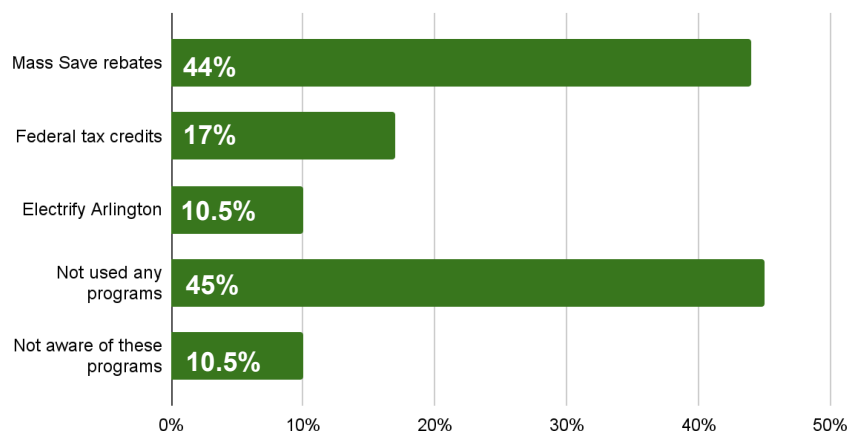


Transitioning Off Fossil Fuels

More than half of respondents (55%) have used at least one program to help them replace fossil fuel appliances in their homes. The Mass Save program was most commonly used, with 44% of respondents reporting that they have claimed a Mass Save rebate and 17% reporting that they have claimed a federal tax credit.

10% of respondents have used the [Electrify Arlington](#) program, which was launched in November 2022 and includes a website with many resources, courses and events, and volunteer energy coaches. Another 10% of respondents indicated that they were not aware of any of these programs that can help them replace fossil fuel appliances.

Have you used any programs that help replace fossil fuel appliances? (Select all that apply)



One in eight respondents (13%) reported that they have already transitioned their homes off fossil fuels. Another quarter (24%) say that they plan to seek assistance in transitioning their homes off fossil fuels.

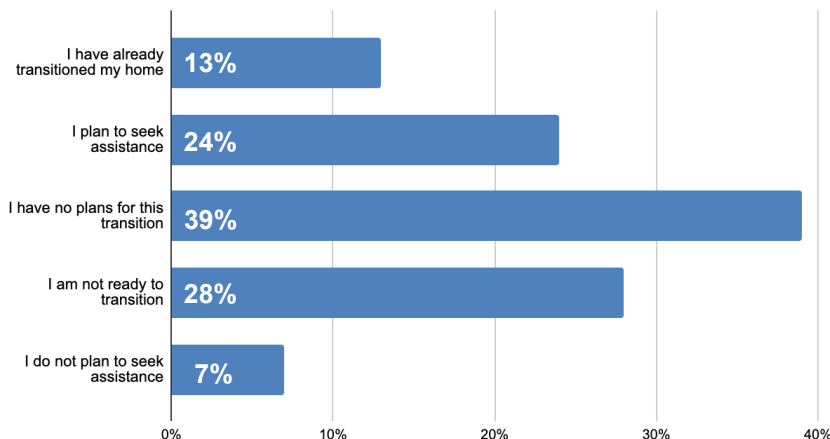
Nearly two-thirds of respondents (63%), however, indicated that they have no plans for this transition, are not ready to transition, and/or do not plan to seek assistance in this transition.

When asked under what conditions they would replace their gas appliances with electric appliances, almost one in five residents indicated that they do not have gas in their home – either because their home simply does not have gas (13%) or they have already transitioned to an all-electric home (6%).

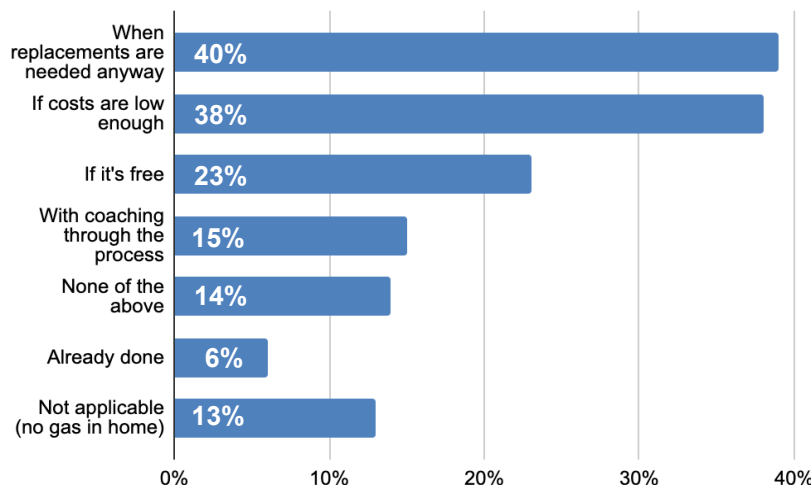
Of the residents with gas in their homes, 82% indicated that they would be willing to replace their gas appliances with electric ones in order to retire the local gas pipes, if certain conditions were met. Nearly half (49%) said they would be willing to switch from gas to electric appliances when they needed to replace their gas appliances anyway. A similar percentage (47%) said they would be willing to do so if costs were low enough, while 29% would be willing to do so if the electric appliances were free. One in five (19%) would want coaching through the process.

Almost one in five respondents who have gas in their homes (18%), however, would not be willing to replace their gas appliances with electric appliances even if their gas appliances needed to be replaced anyway and the electric appliances were free.

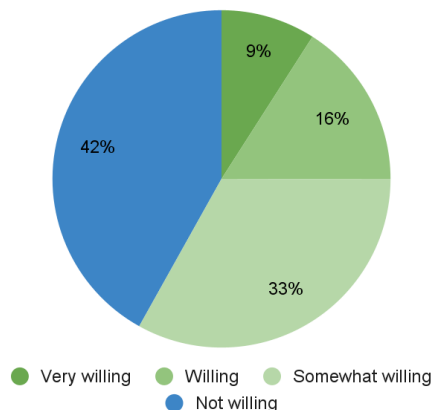
What are your plans for transitioning your home off fossil fuels? (Select all that apply)



To retire the local gas pipes, under what conditions would you replace gas appliances with electric ones?



Would you be willing to participate in conversations with your neighbors about retiring natural gas infrastructure in your neighborhood?



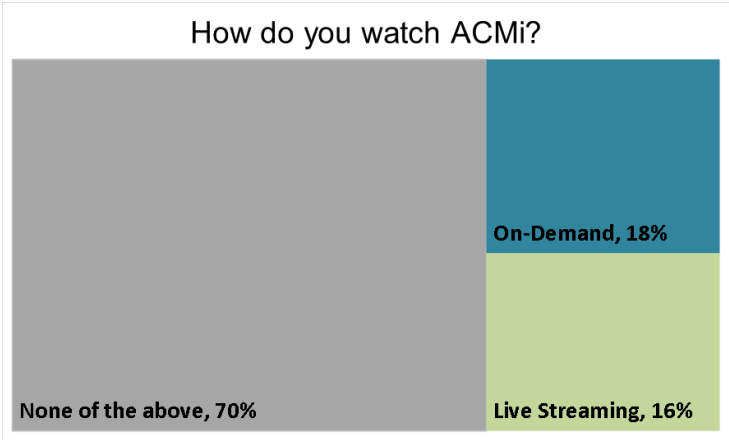
Most respondents (58%) would be willing to participate in conversations with their neighbors about retiring natural gas infrastructure in their neighborhood, with only 9% very willing to do so.

Many respondents (42%) would not be willing to engage in these conversations. Responses to the previous question suggest, however, that roughly a third of these respondents do not have gas in their homes (and not because they transitioned from gas to electricity themselves). Subtracting these respondents, since they probably don't have gas pipelines near their homes, indicates that more than a quarter of all respondents (29%) have gas in their homes and are not willing to talk with their neighbors about retiring their neighborhood's gas infrastructure.

In summary, a majority of Arlington residents are aware of natural gas leaks and their health and environmental impacts, have taken steps to replace fossil fuel appliances in their homes, and are willing to consider transitioning away from fossil fuels in their neighborhood.

ARLINGTON COMMUNITY MEDIA (ACMi)

Arlington's Cable Access Station: [Arlington Community Media Inc.](#) (ACMi) is Arlington's nonprofit station, offering informative, educational, and government programming while fostering community voices. ACMi provides resources and opportunities for Arlington residents to create and access local media content. ACMi asked a few questions to better understand how residents engage with its programming and explore opportunities for deeper connections. The results provide insights into viewing habits, popular content, and ways the community is willing to support their local media resource.



How often do you watch ACMi programming?

The survey revealed that 92% of respondents currently watch ACMi programming less than once a month. Among those tuning in, 18% prefer watching On-Demand, while 16% access content via live streaming.

How do you watch ACMi? Which ACMi channels do you watch?

Seventy-one of respondents indicated they do not watch any specific ACMi channel, though a notable portion engages with the Government (18%), Public (15%), and Education (9%) channels.

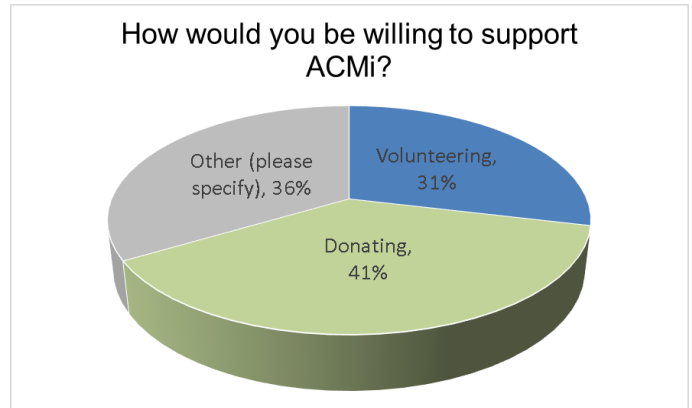
Which ACMi channels do you watch?		
Answer Choices	Responses	
None of the above	71%	1811
Public	15%	382
Education	9%	231
Government	18%	462
Answered	2565	
Skipped	703	

Which of these locally produced shows have you watched?

Engagement with locally produced shows varies significantly, with 65% of respondents reporting they never tune in to the listed programs. However, many expressed interest in specific content, particularly those focused on local governance. Programs like Select Board Meetings (17%) and Town Meetings (16%) garnered the most attention, reflecting strong community interest in civic matters. Other notable areas of interest include School Committee Meetings (11%), ACMi News (10%), and AHS Sports/News (8%). These responses highlight diverse levels of audience engagement and reveal which types of local programming resonate most with viewers.

How would you be willing to support ACMi?

41% of respondents expressed interest in supporting ACMi through donations, reflecting strong community backing. In contrast, 36% chose "Other," citing a range of reasons such as unfamiliarity with ACMi, not watching TV or having cable, funding ACMi with tax, already being members or donors, or simply a lack of interest. 31% of respondents expressed enthusiasm for contributing their time and skills as volunteers. These findings reveal valuable opportunities to deepen engagement and expand support within the community!

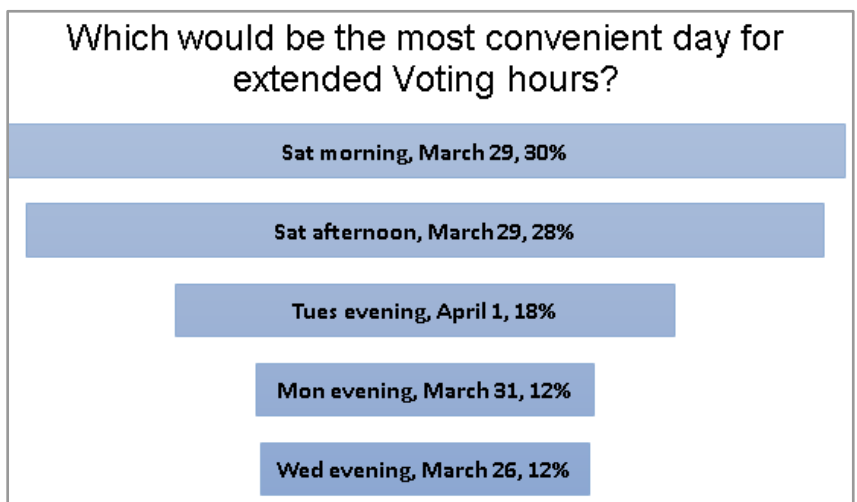


ACMi remains dedicated to serving the Arlington community by providing accessible, high-quality content that informs, educates, and entertains. Based on the survey feedback, ACMi will explore new ways to engage viewers and expand its reach through innovative programming and outreach efforts.

CIVIC ENGAGEMENT

Arlington Town Election is Saturday, April 5. Early voting at the Clerk's Office will extend beyond regular office hours. Which would be the most convenient day for extended hours?

Town Meeting recommended local legislation in 2022 that would allow for in-person early voting on one weekend day and one weeknight until 7 pm. The Town Clerk has offered Saturday hours from 10 a.m. - 2 p.m. for a few years. The responses confirm that Saturday daytime hours are helpful for voters, and Tuesday evening was the best weeknight option.



What comes to mind when you think of "civic engagement"?

Diverse views on what civic engagement means and how community members participate in civic life came from the 67% of respondents. After reviewing open responses to identify common themes, key themes were grouped to facilitate analysis and to provide residents, staff, and Town leaders with a sense of what "civic engagement" means to individuals. Voting and democratic participation emerged

as the most recognized form of civic engagement. Participating in elections at all levels—local, state, and national—and the importance of being informed voters was stressed. Many highlighted participating in voter registration, trying to boost turnout, and supporting activities like volunteering at polls or canvassing as being civically engaged.

Volunteering and Service to the Community was another significant theme, with residents describing contributions to local nonprofits, schools, and community programs. Activities ranged from park cleanups and mutual aid networks to skill-based services like mentoring or tutoring.

Engaging in Local Government and Public Decision-Making through attending public meetings, providing input during hearings, serving on boards and committees, and engaging in municipal governance discussions.

Advocacy and Civic Activism were frequently mentioned to address systemic issues and promote change. Respondents described organizing and participating in campaigns, protests, and coalitions focused on topics such as social justice, climate action, and housing reform.

Community Events and Social Connection responses emphasized the importance of fostering social ties and promoting civic pride. Respondents highlighted events such as festivals, neighborhood gatherings, and cultural celebrations that bring people together, enhance community cohesion, and strengthen social networks.

Education and Awareness: A significant number of respondents emphasized staying informed as a critical part of civic engagement. This includes keeping up with local news, attending workshops, engaging in community discussions, and helping to educate others about civic opportunities and community issues.

Building Community Relationships and Networks was another key theme. Initiatives such as neighborhood watch programs, mutual aid networks, and diversity-focused efforts encouraged inclusivity and collaboration. These actions highlight the relational aspect of civic engagement, where fostering trust and mutual support is as important as formal participation.

Holding Local Leaders Accountable: Activities like monitoring public meetings, providing feedback on policies, and engaging directly with elected representatives were commonly mentioned. A number of comments cited the need for greater transparency, responsiveness, and accessible leadership.

Civic Responsibility and Personal Contribution: included fulfilling personal and legal responsibilities, such as serving on juries, paying taxes, and encouraging others to participate.

Challenges and Barriers to Engagement were also identified, with respondents citing frustrations with bureaucracy, time constraints, and feelings of exclusion. Other challenges included a lack of awareness or easy accessibility of information and unresponsive leaders, which can discourage participation. These insights point toward opportunities to improve engagement, inclusivity, and accessibility.

Shaping the Future through Policy Influence: Respondents mentioned advocating for reforms in housing, transportation, and environmental planning, participating in long-term planning, and contributing to strategic discussions about the town's direction.

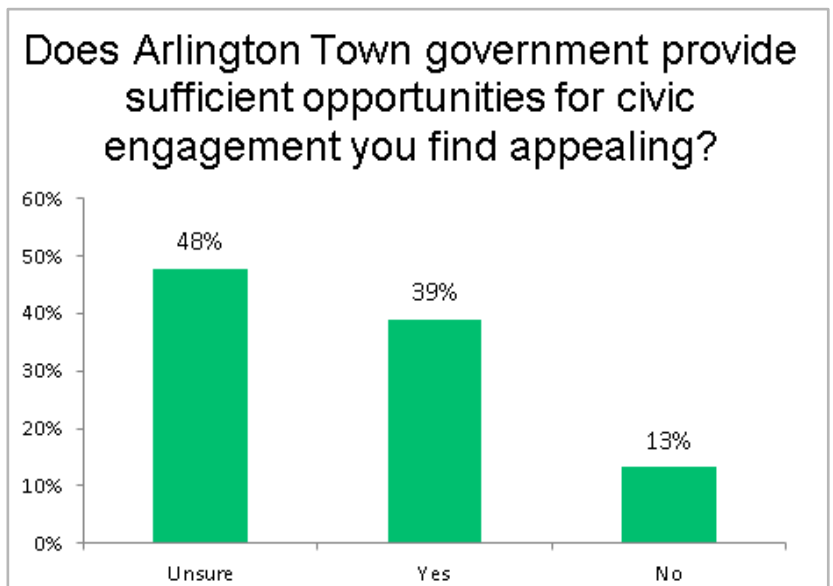
This snapshot of civic engagement offers valuable insights into fostering greater participation and addressing barriers that limit involvement. By exploring the diverse ways residents understand and engage in civic activities, we can work toward creating a more inclusive and active community. Civic engagement takes many forms, from formal actions like voting and attending meetings to informal efforts such as volunteering and educating others. These findings underscore both the opportunities and challenges of building a truly participatory community, while also pointing to key areas for further exploration and growth, such as:

- **Barriers to Engagement:** What structural and cultural challenges prevent people from participating?
- **Inclusivity and Representation:** How can underrepresented groups be better included in civic processes?
- **Impact Assessment:** What are the tangible outcomes of different forms of engagement, from volunteering to activism?
- **Long-Term Trends:** How do perceptions of civic engagement change over time and in response to shifting political or social climates?

Answers to these questions may provide new insights into how to strengthen participation and address barriers to engagement. By understanding the diverse ways that residents conceptualize and practice civic engagement, we can help build more inclusive and participatory communities.

Does Arlington Town government provide sufficient opportunities for civic engagement you find appealing?

Of the 2,743 who responded to this question, about half the respondents (49%) were unsure about this, but a significant proportion (39%) of respondents indicated satisfaction with civic engagement activities provided by the Town government, while only 13% found them to be lacking.



Are you aware of the Civic Academy?

Only 27% of respondents were familiar with the Arlington Civic Academy, a six-week program designed to educate residents on the inner workings of Town government. The academy offers insights into municipal processes and empowers participants with the knowledge to engage meaningfully in civic life. It's an easy entrance for those looking to serve on Town Committees, run for Town Meeting, or simply become more actively involved in their community.

Are you aware of the Young Arlington Collaborative?

Only 10% of respondents were aware of [Young Arlington Collaborative](#), which is aimed at engaging youth and young adults who live, attend school, or work in Arlington. Its primary focus is fostering connections and involvement among the town's younger population through collaborative efforts and programs. The Collaborative works to provide opportunities for social engagement, skill development, and community participation.

Are you aware of the Young Arlington Collaborative?		
Answer	Responses	
Yes	10%	288
No	90%	2499
Answered		2787
Skipped		481

In what ways could Arlington provide more opportunities for civic engagement? The survey revealed 36% of respondents (1,184 out of 3,268) offered suggestions to enhance civic engagement within the community. Key areas for improvement include communication, accessibility, inclusivity, event programming, and modernization. Below is an overview of their responses, organized into major themes and ranked by frequency of mention.

Respondents expressed the importance of **Communication and Awareness** to improve public awareness of civic opportunities. Recommendations included: the establishment of a comprehensive **calendar of events**; improved information dissemination, more **electronic mail, newsletters, social media platforms**, and community notice boards; the development of an accessible and updated municipal **website** featuring details on **meetings and decisions**; and the **reinstatement of the Arlington Advocate** as a primary news publication.

Many respondents expressed a desire for greater **Accessibility and Inclusivity** to civic engagement opportunities. Suggested improvements included: **hybrid/remote meeting options**, scheduling **meetings for evenings** and weekends, and **providing accommodations** for seniors (transportation), parents (childcare), and marginalized groups by ensuring accessibility for renters, low-income families, and non-citizens.

Respondents proposed **Engagement through Events and Programs**. Recommendations included: celebrations like Town Day, arts fairs, or volunteer days; holding neighborhood forums and block parties to involve residents in decision-making; and developing casual meet-and-greet events with town officials.

Respondents highlighted the importance of civic **Education and Information** to empower residents to participate effectively. Suggested initiatives included: offering a Civic Academy to educate on Town government and civic processes; providing informational resources on Town Meeting agendas, ballot measures, and zoning changes; creating workshops and panels on topics of community interest (e.g., housing, sustainability).

Respondents suggested ways to **Support Volunteerism** and make volunteering more accessible and appealing. These included: creating a centralized database of volunteer opportunities; offering short-term or low-commitment tasks for busy residents; and recognizing volunteers through awards or public acknowledgments.

Suggestions emphasized the need for greater **Transparency and Listening to Residents**. Recommendations included: holding open office hours or Q&A sessions with officials; offering clearer

explanations of how public input influences decisions; creating citizen advisory groups to help shape policies.

Respondents expressed interest in **Fostering Stronger Community Connections**, such as supporting block parties, neighborhood improvement projects, and collaborative art initiatives; creating informal gatherings, spaces like community centers or libraries; and offering activities for underserved groups, including seniors and non-English speakers.

Others supported **Targeted Outreach to Marginalized/Specific Groups**, including targeting seniors with tailored programs and transportation options; developing civic programs for teens and young adults to build early engagement; and reaching out to immigrants, renters, and those new to town.

Suggestions for **Modernizing Tools for Civic Engagement** by leveraging technology to make engagement easier and accessible were: **developing a town app** for submitting feedback, reporting issues, and finding opportunities; using QR codes in public spaces to link to engagement opportunities; and streamlining online surveys and tools for public input.

Finally, respondents suggested exploring **Policy and Structural Changes** to improve civic participation, such as aligning elections with state and federal election days to boost turnout; evaluating the town government structure (e.g., introducing a mayor or city council model), and promoting turnover in appointed committees to increase diversity of voices.

The feedback indicates that residents value opportunities to engage with their community but see room for improvement in communication, accessibility, inclusivity, transparency, and technological tools.

RESIDENTIAL BIKE RACKS

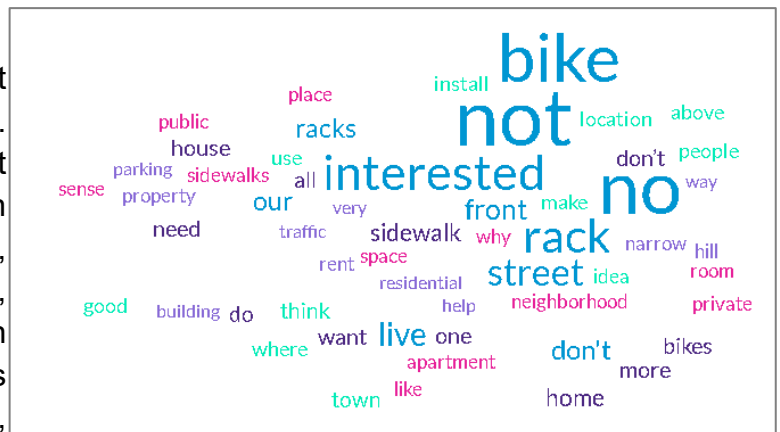
Would you be interested in installing a bike rack in front of your home, in the street or sidewalk? While there is no current or officially proposed program to help residents install bike racks in front of their homes, the purpose of the survey question was to gauge interest in such a program. Responses below were analyzed to attempt to answer two basic questions which were conflated into one.¹

Answer Choices	Responses	
Help with the cost of purchasing a bike rack	11%	183
Help with installation of a bike rack	8%	137
Guidelines for safe and appropriate installation	8%	124
Other (please specify)	73%	1195
	Answered	1639
	Skipped	1629

How many people would be interested in a program to install bike racks? What forms of assistance would be helpful?

Positive Responses: Out of 1,639 respondents, 444 individuals (27%) expressed interest in installing a bike rack, specifically seeking assistance with purchasing costs, installation support, or guidelines for safe and appropriate setup. An additional 55 respondents showed interest through the 'Other' category, bringing the total to 499 (30%) who positively supported this option. Some respondents also highlighted other needs, such as covered bike racks for weather protection, increased bike storage on private property (particularly for renters and condo owners), and broader improvements in Arlington's bicycle infrastructure. Others called for enhancements to related amenities like sidewalks, crosswalks, and bus services.

Negative Responses: 1,629 people (50%) skipped the question, which is interpreted here as a lack of interest. In addition, many of the 1,195 respondents who selected “Other” used it to express opinions ranging from ambiguity (“Kinda?”) to lack of interest (“No”, “Not interested”) to stronger opposition implying lack of interest among a large majority (85%) for this option. Some reasons provided for lack of interest were: Renters/apartment, not their decision to make, no perceived need at their location, especially on quiet/residential streets, physical constraints such as lack of space in front of dwelling, lack of sidewalks, concerns about blocking access for cars, wheelchairs, etc., animosity towards bicycles and bicyclists in general, etc.



¹ The author, editors, and submitter of the combined question regret any confusion that may have arisen due to the conflated question.

EDUCATION: ARLINGTON PUBLIC SCHOOLS

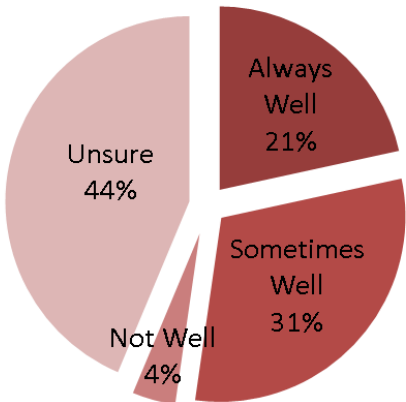
Does your household include students in the following categories? (Future Student, PreK-5th, 6th-12th, Home School, Private School, APS Student, No APS student, Past APS Student)?

Nearly half of the survey respondents (49%) indicated that they do not currently have any APS students living in their household. Among the remaining participants, 19% reported having students in grades 6-12, while 18% have children in Pre-K through 5th grade. Additionally, 15% shared that their children previously attended APS, 12% have children who will attend APS in the future, and 3% have children enrolled in private schools. Notably, none of the respondents identified as homeschooling their children or being APS students themselves.

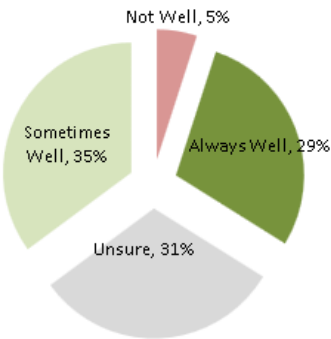
How well is the school district serving students and families?

Thirty-one percent indicated ‘Sometimes Well’ and 22% indicated ‘Always Well’ down 1% from last year. On the other hand, 44% were unsure about this while 4% stated that the school district did not serve students and families well.

How well is the school district serving students and families?

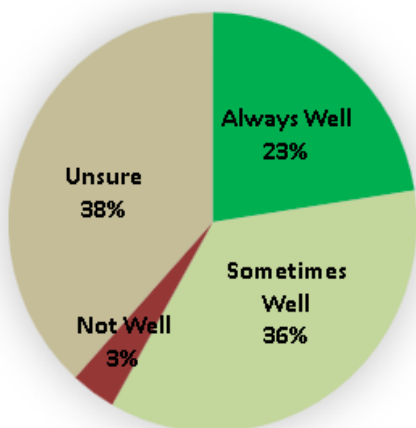


How well funded do you think the Arlington Public Schools are?



How well funded do you think the Arlington Public Schools are? Overall, about two-thirds (64%) of respondents think APS is well funded, with 35% indicating ‘Sometimes Well-funded’ and 29% indicating ‘Always Well-funded’. Compared to last year, 8% of respondents have changed their opinion from ‘Always well-funded’ to ‘Sometimes well-funded’ category.

How well maintained are APS facilities, classrooms, and community spaces?



How well-maintained are APS facilities, classrooms, and community spaces?

Overall, there was an improvement in this area compared to last year, as 10% more respondents (58%) indicated 'Always' or 'Sometimes Well'. Thirty-eight responded 'Unsure' and 3% said 'Not Well'.

In what ways could the business community partner with APS or the broader community contribute to APS programming? From the 648 responses, the suggestions included internships, mentorship programs, financial literacy programs, facility improvements, and more.

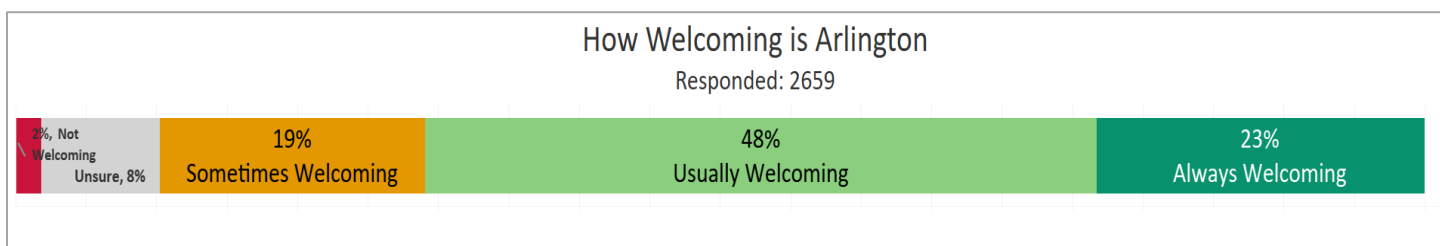
TOWN SATISFACTION: DIVERSITY, EQUITY, and INCLUSION

Arlington is home to many diverse groups of people and to a wide variety of ethnicities, nationalities, incomes, races, gender identities, sexual orientations, and abilities. The town prioritizes well-being, safety, fairness, and inclusion of all in our community. This section highlights how respondents feel about safety and inclusivity in Arlington.

Currently, how satisfied are you living in Arlington? The satisfaction ratings among respondents were overall very positive and much like the previous year, with 50% responding with 'Very Satisfied', 42% 'Satisfied', and only 7% 'Very Dissatisfied' (1%) or 'Dissatisfied' (6%). While no variation in satisfaction was observed across gender, age, or disability groups, owners rated 8% higher on 'very satisfied' compared to renters.

How welcoming is the community of Arlington?

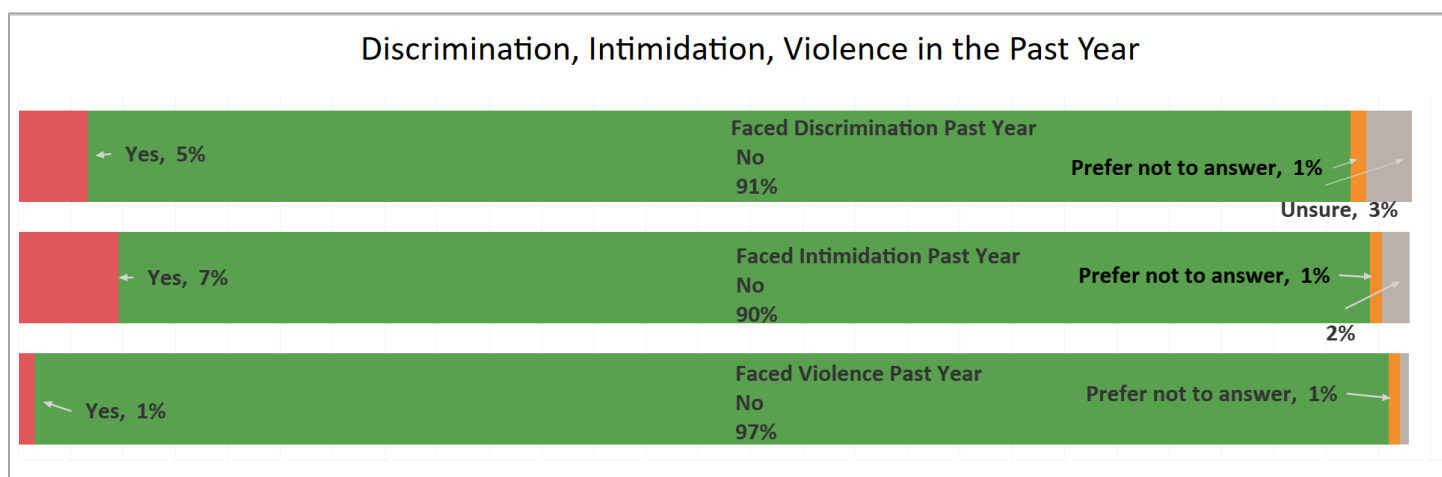
The Arlington community is widely regarded as a welcoming place, with 48% of respondents



describing it as "Usually Welcoming" and an additional 23% calling it "Always Welcoming." These proportions are almost similar to the previous year's, except a drop of 4% in 'Usually Welcoming' category and a rise of 3% in the 'Somewhat Welcoming' category. There were 8% 'Unsure' and 2% selecting 'Not Welcoming'.

In Arlington, in the past year, have you personally experienced discrimination, intimidation, or violence?

While violence in Arlington was extremely low last year, as 97% reported not facing any violence, 5% did report facing discrimination, and 7% reported facing intimidation. In all three categories, 1% to 4% of respondents either chose not to answer or expressed uncertainty. These figures remain the same as last year.

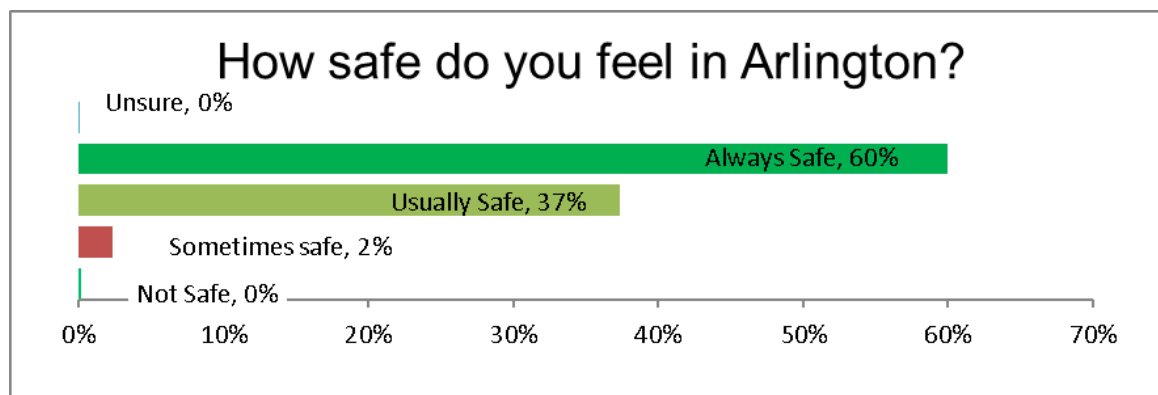


When combining discrimination, intimidation, and violence to see the proportion of respondents who reported experiencing all three, about 40 respondents indicated experiencing all of the indicators. Approximately 190 respondents, accounting for 2%, reported experiencing at least two of the categories. While investigating income, precinct, and gender identity, respondents in the lowest income group (31) reported significantly higher negative experiences, with only 67% reporting not experiencing any of these, compared to an average of 89% for other income groups. Additionally, those who did not know their precinct (42 respondents or 33%) were observed to have experienced at least one of the categories, which was significantly higher compared to those who knew their precincts (an average of 10%). Across Precincts, 9 (17%), 1 (15%), and 6 & 7 (13% each) stood out with slightly higher reporting of such experiences. Further, respondents who did not identify as male or female reported having experienced at least one of these 15-30% more than those who identified male or female. Similarly, among those who speak other languages, 75% Chinese, 57% Arabic, and 55% Hebrew expressed not having experienced any of these, which is

much lower than speakers of other non-English languages such as French, German, Hindi, – Marathi, Spanish, Portuguese, etc. These variations provide insights into certain groups of residents having more negative experiences.

How Safe Do You Feel in Arlington?

Arlington is considered a very safe community, as found by 97% of the respondents of which 60% found Arlington to be ‘Always Safe’ and 37% ‘Usually Safe’ with 6 respondents choosing ‘Not Safe’ and 2 respondents ‘Unsure’.



SUMMARY

Thank you to everyone who took the time to complete the survey. We value your input and encourage you to share any feedback about the survey or this report. We also welcome your suggestions and follow-up questions for next year’s survey.

The 2025 Arlington Town Survey report provides a comprehensive summary of responses on key topics such as trees, civic engagement, and fossil fuels. To ensure accuracy and clarity, the report was created using AI tools and software, including Gemini, Jasper, Tableau, Excel, and Perplexity, which assisted in summarizing content, refining language, and enhancing grammar.

Key points are:

- **Survey Overview:** 3,268 responses were collected online and via paper copies between January 1 and March 4, 2024. The survey focused on Net Zero Action Plan, Tree Canopy Plan, Arlington Community Media, and Civic Engagement.
- **Demographics:** Respondents were primarily White (87%), female (57%), aged 35-64, homeowners (77%), and with high annual income (39% over \$200,000). Many moved to Arlington from nearby towns like Cambridge and Somerville. Many survey respondents (17%)

would still choose to live in Arlington if they could live anywhere they wanted, while others preferred a move to Cambridge or warmer, coastal areas.

- **Tree Committee:** A majority (59%) support increasing the town's tree budget, and 74% are willing to plant trees on their property with assistance. Awareness of the town's multi-year tree canopy plan was low (58%).
- **Fossil Fuels:** Most respondents are aware and concerned about natural gas leaks, with many having smelled them. Over half have used programs to replace fossil fuel appliances. There's willingness to transition to electric appliances with certain conditions and to discuss retiring gas infrastructure with neighbors.
- **Arlington Community Media (ACMi):** Most respondents watch ACMi programming less than once a month. Support for ACMi includes donations and volunteering.
- **Civic Engagement:** Respondents have diverse views on civic engagement, including voting, volunteering, and local government participation. About 40% are satisfied with the town's civic engagement opportunities. Suggestions for improvement include better communication, accessibility, and events.
- **Residential Bike Racks:** While there is growing interest in installing bike racks outside homes, the idea has also sparked concerns and opposition.
- **Education:** Nearly half of respondents do not have students in Arlington Public Schools. 22% are very satisfied with the APS and about two-thirds think APS is well funded.
- **Town Satisfaction and Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion:** Satisfaction with living in Arlington is high, with 50% 'very satisfied.' Most find the community welcoming. Reports of discrimination, intimidation, and violence exist, with some groups experiencing these more than others. Arlington is considered a very safe community.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS: 2025 Town of Arlington Survey Report

Johanna Meyer: Lead: Survey Team, Compilation of Submissions, Co-author, Editor

Lisa Hota: Edit Lead: Survey Team, Editor, Co-author

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Micheal Brownstein: Reviewer

Carol Murray: Reviewer

Weslie Etienne Pierre: Reviewer

Claire Ricker: Editor, Reviewer

You are invited to submit questions for review and consideration by the Envision Arlington Committee prior to November. All submissions will be evaluated by the survey team for potential inclusion.

Selected questions will be collaboratively refined with the submitter to ensure they meet standards of objectivity, clarity, and conciseness, maximizing the inclusion of as many questions as possible for publication online in January. When submitting your question(s), please specify whether you would like the survey team to analyze the results for your review and edits, if you intend to conduct your own analysis and submit the findings, or if you prefer the final report to include only the graphical or tabular results. The survey will close in March, with the final report available in May at:

<https://www.arlingtonma.gov/town-governance/boards-and-committees/envision-arlington/survey-results>